Venkatachalapathy teases out the historical and emotional contours of this understudied contribution in his characteristically vivid style, his work rich with rare material. A milestone in the annals of modern Indian historical writing'—T.M. Krishna, winner of the Magsaysay Award

'An exhaustively researched, finely grained and deeply felt telling of one of the Swadeshi era's more remarkable stories: one man's struggle to launch an Indian shipping company to rival Britain's maritime supremacy' —Sunil Khilnani, author of *Incarnations: India in 50 Lives*

'In a remarkable combination of fabulous research and vivid storytelling, *Swadeshi Steam* portrays an extraordinary indigenous shipping enterprise and its founder V.O. Chidambaram Pillai against the backdrop of [the British] empire and globalization. Venkatachalapathy has pursued his subject over four decades and has ensured that no historian need bother again. This is an altogether engrossing and instructive book on a pivotal yet forgotten moment in Indian nationalism'—Srinath Raghavan, author of *The Most Dangerous Place: A History of the United States in South Asia*

'Set against the backdrop of the Swadeshi movement in the Madras Presidency, *Swadeshi Steam* is a story of an ordinary person's challenge to the mighty British Empire, especially its command of the seas. A.R. Venkatachalapathy weaves together a magnificent history of the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company and V.O. Chidambaram Pillai from hitherto unknown sources. *Swadeshi Steam* is the history of an Indian entrepreneur and visionary who dared to challenge British might; it is a history of business and competition in which the players were at once canny and ruthless; and it is a history of Indian anti-colonialism that begins with Swadeshi and moves into labour movements in the era of World War I. A history of a human actor, his aspirations and heartbreak, Venkatachalapathy's immensely learned and readable book narrates a multi-layered history of colonial south India'—Rochona Majumdar, professor and author of *Art Cinema and India's Forgotten Futures*